

Practice Paper 20 — Answer Scheme

Paper 2 — Comprehension

Sections B & C

Note to teachers and students

- Marks are awarded for **meaning**, not for exact words. Where a quotation is required, it has been indicated in inverted commas.
- Where the question asks for **own words**, a candidate who lifts directly from the text receives **zero** for that mark unless the lifted phrase is unavoidable.
- For language and tone questions, accept any reasonable alternative that clearly fits the textual evidence.

Section B — Text 3 Answer Scheme [20 marks]

Q1. [2] — “The calm indifference of all broken machines”

1 mark for understanding that the machine seems **uncaring** / **unbothered** by the failure.

1 mark for explaining that it displays the error **as if nothing important has happened**, showing the chilling contrast between the seriousness of the outage and the machine’s blank, ordinary response.

Sample answer: The phrase suggests that the machine is entirely **unmoved** by what has happened; it presents the failure as routine, which makes the moment feel even more unsettling because the narrator alone understands how serious it is.

Q2. [2] — Wind “leaning on the walls”

1 mark for identifying **personification** — the wind is given a deliberate, human action.

1 mark for explaining that the wind seems **purposeful** and **testing**, as if it is intelligently probing the building’s weaknesses, which makes it feel threatening rather than random.

Q3. [2] — Following her training

1 mark each for any two of:

- She **logged the time of the outage**.
- She **checked the back-up modem** (and the secondary antenna).
- She **noted the wind speed and temperature**.
- She **made a cup of tea** in accordance with the storm protocol that scientists should remain “warm and unhurried”.

Q4. [1] — “Just yet”

1 mark: The phrase suggests she is **deliberately postponing** the thought of being alone — she knows the fear is coming and is **holding it at a distance** through routine. (Accept: she is aware she will eventually have to confront it.)

Q5. [2] — “At the time”

1 mark for understanding that her **original feelings** were of **quiet pride / virtue / professionalism** in volunteering.

1 mark for explaining that the phrase “at the time” signals a **shift**: now, faced with the storm and the isolation, the decision feels **less wise / more frightening / less heroic** than it once did.

Q6. [2] — Voice as a “steadying thing”

1 mark — The **silence** of the empty station was unsettling, and her voice **breaks** that silence.

1 mark — Hearing her own clear, ordinary speech **reassures her** that she is calm and in control; speaking aloud is a way of **grounding herself** and resisting panic.

Q7. [3] — Comparing the generator to a sleeping child

1 mark for identifying the **simile** and its emotional effect — it makes the generator feel **precious and fragile**, like something whose life she is responsible for.

1 mark each for **two** clearly quoted and explained details (max 2):

- “I stood up so fast that the chair fell over” — the suddenness shows **instinctive alarm**, like a parent reacting to a child.
- “holding a torch I did not need” — she acts on **instinct rather than reason**, showing how shaken she is.
- “the way one listens to a sleeping child whose breathing has briefly changed” — captures **quiet, attentive dread**.
- “I do not remember what I said to it. I remember that I said something.” — she spoke to it tenderly, as one would to a child.

Each detail must be **quoted** and **explained**.

Q8. [1] — The fallen chair

1 mark: It shows the narrator is **so alarmed** that she has abandoned her usual orderly habits — the small disregard for tidiness reveals how **seriously frightened** she is, and how completely her attention has been seized by the generator. (Accept: it shows her **instinctive, unthinking reaction**.)

Q9. [2] — Fear as “useful”

1 mark — The fear was **brief and clarifying**: it forced her to recognise **how much she had been taking for granted** (warmth, light, safety).

1 mark — It was useful because it **restored her perspective** — it made her **grateful** for what she had and **calmer** afterwards, rather than leaving her permanently anxious.

Reject answers that lift “pure and short and useful” without rewording.

Q10. [2] — “A serious and ancient piece of work”

1 mark — The storm feels **immense** and **important**, not a passing inconvenience — it is doing **real work** on the landscape.

1 mark — The word **ancient** suggests the blizzard belongs to a **time long before humans** — it dwarfs her and reminds her of her own **smallness** against weather of this scale.

Q11. [1] — Tone of the final sentence

1 mark — Any **one** of: **quietly proud**, **self-deprecating**, **reflective**, **gently humorous**, **satisfied**. (Reject: **boastful**, **arrogant** — the understated phrase “not, on the whole, been bad company” is too modest for these.)

Section C — Text 4 Answer Scheme [25 marks]

Q12. [2] — “Wonder and unease”

1 mark — **Wonder**: the public feels **amazement** / **awe** that science can now achieve something once thought impossible.

1 mark — **Unease**: the public also feels **uncomfortable** / **uncertain**, sensing that reviving extinct species may carry **moral or ecological risks** they cannot yet see clearly.

Q13. [2] — Ecological reasons supporting de-extinction

1 mark each for any two of:

- A mammoth would help **maintain the cold, dry steppe** that locked carbon into the permafrost.
- A thylacine would **restore a top predator** to the Tasmanian ecosystem.
- Reviving lost species could **restore ecological functions** (e.g. predation, grazing) long missing from northern grasslands and Australian forests.
- The ecosystem has been “**progressively unbalanced**” since the thylacine’s loss.

Q14. [2] — The argument from restitution

1 mark — **Restitution** means **making amends** / **putting right** a wrong one has caused.

1 mark — The argument claims that because **humans drove these species to extinction**, humans have a **moral duty** to bring them back where it is possible to do so.

Reject answers that lift “switch the light back on” without rewording.

Q15. [2] — “Quietly and patiently”

1 mark — These words suggest the biologists are **calm, reasonable and non-confrontational**, not shouting or attacking — they make their case **gently**.

1 mark — The phrase also implies they have been **making the same point for a long time** and are **unfailingly steady**, which subtly increases the **credibility** of their objection.

Q16. [2] — Reviving the dead vs rescuing the dying

1 mark — The contrast is between **species that are already extinct** (the “dead”) and species that are **still alive but disappearing** (the “dying”).

1 mark — The writer is pointing out that **money spent on revival** could **save species that still exist**, and that the second option is **more urgent and more achievable**.

Q17. [2] — “An elephant edited to resemble a mammoth”

1 mark — The phrase suggests the writer thinks the revival is **not a true mammoth** but a **modified imitation** of one.

1 mark — It conveys **quiet scepticism**: the science is impressive but produces only a **resemblance**, not the original animal — its behaviour and biology have been **guessed at**, not recovered.

Q18. [1] — “Cautionary tales”

1 mark: To **warn** the reader that **well-meaning introductions** of new or altered species into ecosystems have, in the past, gone **badly wrong** — so we should be cautious about releasing a revived mammoth into modern tundra.

Q19. [2] — “Money is rarely zero-sum”

1 mark — **Zero-sum** means that what one side gains, the other side must lose; **rarely zero-sum** therefore means **funding de-extinction does not automatically reduce funding for endangered species**.

1 mark — Defenders argue that the **philanthropists** who fund a mammoth project are **not the same people** who would otherwise have funded existing conservation, so the two efforts can **coexist**.

Reject answers that lift “zero-sum” without explaining it.

Q20. [1] — Tone of the rhetorical question

1 mark — Any **one** of: **sceptical, probing, challenging, critical, searching**. (Reject: **angry, bitter** — the writer is questioning, not attacking.)

Q21. [2] — Effect of repeating “small, peculiar”

1 mark — The repetition **emphasises modesty / limits**: it stresses that de-extinction is neither grand nor irrelevant, but **narrow in scope and unusual in nature**.

1 mark — The doubling produces a **measured, balanced** effect that **deflates the hype** around de-extinction without dismissing it entirely — fitting the writer’s overall **moderate** position.

Q22. Summary [13 marks total: 6 content + 7 style]

Content points ($\frac{1}{2}$ mark each, max 6 marks). **Eight available content points; candidates should aim for all 8.**

Arguments against de-extinction (Paragraphs 3–4):

- Resources spent on revival could be **better spent saving species still alive** but endangered.
- De-extinction projects are **extremely expensive** (e.g. over one hundred and fifty million dollars per mammoth project).
- The vaquita and others could be **stabilised** for **much less** than a single revival project costs.
- A revived species is **not truly the original** — it is only a **modified imitation** whose behaviour and biology are guessed at.
- Releasing such a creature into a **changed environment** invites **unpredictable ecological consequences**; history shows well-meaning introductions often **go wrong**.

Responses from defenders (Paragraph 5):

- The **gene-editing technologies** developed for de-extinction can **also help existing wildlife** (e.g. coral reefs, the black-footed ferret).
- Funding is **not zero-sum**: philanthropists who back revival are **not** those who would otherwise fund conservation of endangered species.
- To **reject the new science** is to mistake **one battle for the whole war** — both efforts can proceed together.

Sample full-marks summary (78 words):

Critics of de-extinction argue that the funds it consumes could rescue species still alive but vanishing, since revival costs vastly more than stabilising threatened animals. They also note that any restored creature is merely an edited imitation whose release into an altered habitat could cause unforeseen damage. Defenders reply that the gene-editing tools developed can equally aid living wildlife, that philanthropic funding rarely competes directly with conservation, and that dismissing the science wastes a useful, complementary effort.

Length count: 78 words from “Critics” onwards.

— END OF ANSWER SCHEME —